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The climate of literature: A sea change?

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Abstract

This article builds on theoretical, methodological and empirical research on the 'Climate of Literature' having since the early 1960's on and off been pursued at the University of Lund. Literature is regarded as one of several large societal systems. It is hypothesized that during the last few decades basic characteristics of the literary system – just as those of other large societal systems – have come under increasingly strong influence from the economic sector of society. The hypothesis gets some support from quantitative and qualitative data covering two periods of the Swedish literary system, 1876–92 and 1953–76, and having been collected by means of a technique which in the field of bibliometrics has become known as 'citation analysis'. In order to formally test the hypothesis, the periods covered by empirical data have to be extended to include the last quarter of the 20th century. Comparative studies in the area may yield a rich harvest.

Had we but World enough and Time [--]
But at my back I alwaies hear
Times winged Chariot hurrying near.
And yonder all before us lye
Desarts of vast Eternity
Andrew Marvell (1621–1678): *To his Coy Mistress*

1. Introduction

All human societies may be conceptualized as being composed of three very large, mutually interrelated systems: a *cultural* system of ideas, a *social* system af actions, and a material system of physical artefacts. In empirical reality, of course, ideas, actions and artefacts are very closely intertwined, so that it may be extremely difficult to entangle the ideational, actional and material aspects from each other. The fact that this is so is no argument against the analytical distinction, of course. But it makes empirical analyses difficult, especially since there are other types of societal subsystems, all of which, in all societies, necessarily encompass elements of these three basic systems: the cultural system of ideas, the social system of action, and the material system of artefacts.

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For theoretical purposes each of these three systems may be used to characterize any society – from either the structural or the processual side of the system, or from both sides. It is often practical, however, to regard societies as being structured primarily by a central element in the ideational, cultural system: its value system (witness a large number of comparative studies; for recent examples, see, for instance, Lipset (1993), Inglehart (1995), Schwartz (1994)).

Actually, all societal structures may be understood in terms of two pairs of very basic value orientations:

Cognitive/normative value orientation
and
Expressive/instrumental value orientation.

Each one of the two pairs of value orientations may be regarded as being defined by two pairs of basic values: the values of truth and rigtheousness, beauty and usefulness, respectively. These value orientations are very basic. They seem indeed to be virtually timeless. They may be expressed in terms of four Indo-European verbs – Latin *sapere/debere*, *esse/facere*; cf. French *savoir/devoir*, *être/faire* – having their functional counterparts in other families of languages. These very basic value orientations were discussed already by early Greek philosophers, in terms of *Logos* and *Ethos*, *Pathos* and *Praxis*. In the 18th century, Friedrich Schiller wrote poetry about them, as did many of his precursors and followers in various parts of Europe. Students of modern advertising and public relations also use them (cf. Pollay, 1985; Nowak, 1992: 182). All societal institutions have emerged out of these two pairs of value orientations, and they are still gradually developing around them. The history of basic societal structures and processes may thus be interpreted in terms of an ever-growing functional differentiation (cf., for instance, Parsons, 1966) between a relatively small number of societal institutions, each based on a specific constellation of value orientations defined by the two pairs of basic value orientations. Within each of these institutions, the three basic systems of ideas, actions and artefacts are to be found, of course, so that all institution-based societal subsystems may be conceptualized from an ideational, an actional and/or an artefactual perspective.

Fig. 1, visualizing the 'Great Wheel of Culture in Society', offers a typology of large societal institutions grouped around the two pairs of basic value orientations: expressive vs. instrumental value orientation, and cognitive vs. normative value orientation (Rosengren, 1984a,b, 1985a; 1994: 5; Rosengren and Windahl, 1989: 159ff.; cf. for instance, Berger and Berger, 1972: 20; Giddens, 1984: 17). The typology is shaped as a so-called circumplex (Guttman, 1954; cf. Katz et al., 1973; Shepard, 1978; Lumsden and Wilson, 1981). The circumplex locates the main societal subsystems in a two-dimensional space in a way which suggests their closest neighbours in society: the system of economy being located between the political and technological systems; literature, between art and scholarship, etc. The circumplex is similar, of course, to several other, more or less Weberian or Parsonian typologies of societal structures, but mostly so, perhaps, to the one presented by Namenwirth and Bibbee (1976), which includes also the element of time, however (cf. Namenwirth and Weber, 1987: 67).

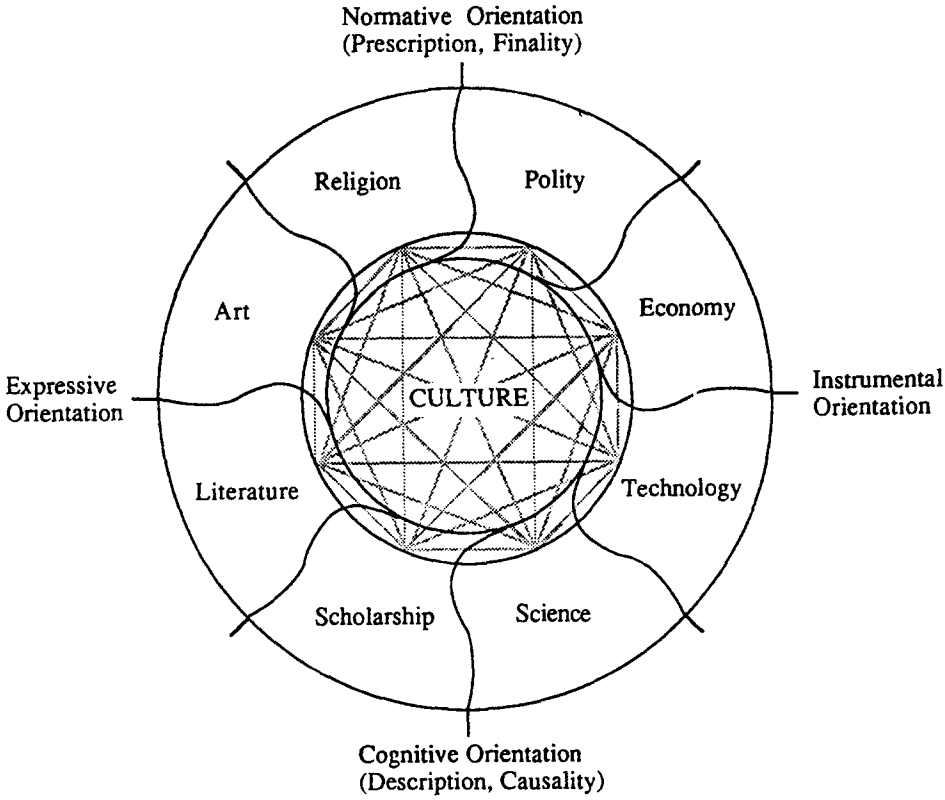

Fig. 1. The Great Wheel of Culture in Society.

The figure represents the three basic systems of ideas, actions and artefacts by means of concentrical circles. At the centre of the circumplex – the 'hub of the wheel' – we find culture, the ideational system of society. Culture, then, is both cognitively and normatively oriented, both expressive and instrumental. It unites and relates, one to the other, the four basic value orientations and their various sub-systems. Note, however, that – for pictorial reasons – the ideational part of the Great Wheel of Culture has not been divided into eight sectors, although there is no doubt, of course, that each societal sector has its own, specific culture (political culture, economic culture, etc.) – just as the specific cultures are parts and parcels of overarching societal culture.

The dashed network relating the societal sub-systems to each other tells us something about the complexity of the overall system, and of the immense number of communicative and co-ordinating functions fulfilled by society's ideational system, societal culture: 28 first order interdependencies, literally tens of thousands of secondary, tertiary etc. interdependencies and interactions. These relations connect society's institutional subsystems to each other: religion and politics; politics, science

and technology; politics, science, technology and religion – and so on, in never-ending chains of mutual interaction. All such relations may affect both ideas, actions and artefacts of the subsystems, but for pictorial convenience, the lines have been drawn only as going from the system of action within one institutional subsystem to that of another.

This way of pictorial representation also signals, however, that all these relations have to be established by means of action of one type or another, as a rule backed up by a very special type of action: communication. In all societies, these relations are carried out by means of interpersonal, face-to-face communication. In modern societies, they are often established also by means of mediated interpersonal communication, as well as by organizational and mass communication. As these relations continue, the never-ending process of differentiation between the various societal institutions also continues. The institutions thus grow increasingly differentiated and yet remain mutually interdependent. All of them have to keep some part of general societal culture incorporated within their own substructures, continually balancing specific culture ('political culture', 'economic culture', etc.) against general societal culture.

2. Change and stability

All societies – and all societal systems – change all the time. At the same time, all societies need a measure of stability. A very basic societal problem is thus how to keep a balance beteen change and stability. All main societal subsystems have to handle that problem, one way or the other. The five subsystems of art, literature, scholarship, science and technology, however, are strongly oriented towards change and innovation. Indeed, all of them are systems in which innovations are exchanged against status (and in most cases – especially, of course, cases of technology – against some money as well). A primary function of the two subsystems of polity and economy, on the other hand, is to strike a balance between innovation and stability, while especially the subsystem of religion is oriented towards long-term stability.

The various sectors do not operate independently of each other. They often form different alliances, mutually adapting to each other, expressing themselves in terms of each other. Politics and religion have often been found in an alliance dominating society, manoeuvering between economy and technology within a framework produced, interpreted and expressed in terms of science and scholarship, art and literature. During the better part of this century, the world system has been characterized by national and international conflicts having its roots in the systems of politics and economy. In some parts of the world – primarily, perhaps, the Islamic parts – the religious sector of the Great Wheel of Culture seems to grow increasingly important. On the whole, however, it seems to be a general impression that the system of economy is now the internationally dominating system. The political system often acts only as an executive committee satisfying demands and commands which originate in the economic system and are communicated by way of the national and interna-

tional mass media systems – sometimes actually being enacted as 'Media Events' in those media systems themselves (cf. Dayan and Katz, 1992).

Developments such as these will have some consequences for the societal institutions located in the focus of interest of this journal: 'Literature, the Media and the Arts' – and, indirectly, for the scholarly and scientific study of these societal sectors. How may the supposedly increasing influence of society's economic system upon the societal systems of art and literature be studied empirically and quantitatively, in the way so many other phenomena related to art and literature have been studied during the last few decades? – Some attempts to measure important aspects of the literary system were made in Rosengren (1961, 1968, 1981, 1983, 1984b, 1985a,b, 1987, 1990; cf. Rosengren and Arbelius, 1971; Freeman, 1986; Griswold, 1993). These attempts will be further discussed and enlarged upon below. Towards the end of the article, some preliminary suggestions will be made about ways and means by which an increasing influence from the economic sector of society on its literary sector might be measured in future bibliometric studies.

3. Reward systems

Art and literature are large societal institutions producing innovations in their respective sector of society. An important characteristic of innovation producing institutions is their reward system. The reward systems may be organized according to different principles. In each system there are two different but related types of rewards: material and symbolic rewards. Both types may be granted in more or less institutionalized ways. It is commonplace to distinguish between reward systems based upon market standards and critical standards (Bourdieu, 1971; DiMaggio and Hirsch, 1976), but there are actually a whole set of such systems: patronage of different types, markets, prizes, grants, subsidies etc. (Clark and Clark, 1977; Clark, 1979, 1987).

Crane (1976) presented and discussed a list of four different types of reward systems (cf. Crane, 1992: 111ff.). Rosengren (1983: 19ff.) located the four different types of reward systems within a typology ordering the distinctions just discussed so that they form a Guttman scale – a procedure which, incidentally, gave rise to a fifth type of reward systems (cf. Rosengren, 1990, 1994: 18; Rosengren et al., 1996: 9). The typology is presented in Table 1.

The scale generates several interesting questions. Some such questions discussed by Crane (1976, 1992) concern, for instance,

- the degree of continuity and variety in the innovations produced under different reward systems;
- the change from one system of reward to another;
- the relationship between type of reward system and amount of resources at the disposal of the system.

The scale might also be related to other theoretical arguments, for instance, theories of professionalization and de-professionalization in the media (Windahl and Rosen-

Table 1
A Guttman scale for innovators' reward systems (developed from Crane, 1976)

Innovative product consumed mainly by fellow innovators	Material rewards allocated among innovators mainly by fellow innovators	Symbolic rewards allocated among innovators mainly by fellow innovators	Norms for innovations set mainly by fellow innovators	Ideal type of reward system	Tentative examples
Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Esoteric	Basic science
No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Independent	Applied science
No	No	Yes	Yes	Semi-independent	Technology, elite art and literature
No	No	No	Yes	Sub-cultural	Jazz, radical science
No	No	No	No	Hetero-cultural	Mass media culture (literature, music, etc.)

gren, 1978; Kepplinger and Köcher, 1990). It may be related, say, to the prevalence of the four types of artists listed by Becker (1982): integrated professionals, mavericks, naive artists, and folk artists. It may be related, finally, to the type of ultimate source of moneys available to the system: patron, market, prizes, grants, subsidies etc. (Clark and Clark, 1977; Clark, 1979, 1987).

The five values of the ordinal scale should be seen as ideal types, seldom or never met with *in concreto*. The scale may have its main value, therefore, as a heuristic device for theoretical work. In empirical research it probably has to be modified in various ways. Each of the four items of the scale has to be operationalized on its own conditions and probably also has to be conceptualized as having more than the two values of yes and no. Finally, overall institutions such as literature or science may well be regarded as being composed of a number of sub-institutions, the innovators of which have differential degree of control over the reward system (cf. the examples given in Table 1).

The dynamics in and between innovation producing institutions is considerable. There are two main types of such dynamics: changes *in* and *of* the systems. Single innovations may percolate between societal institutions, and such movements may go both ways. '*Gesunkenes Kulturgut*' was for a long time a key term in European ethnography. A striking and well-known example of percolation in the other direction, as it were, is Shakespeare, who – now the classic dramatist par excellence – originally worked in a heterocultural medium, the popular theatres of Elizabethan London. In the beginning of his career he was looked down upon by an established group of writers, the 'University Wits'. Regarding themselves as serving another system, semi-independent at the very least, and yet anxious not to be overshadowed by Shakespeare, they called him an

"upstart crowe beautified with our feathers ... that supposes he is as well able to bombast out a blank verse as the best of you." (quoted from Legouis and Cazamian, 1930/1957: 411)

It would not be too difficult to find parallels to this quarrel among present-day representatives of semi-independent and heterocultural reward systems such as élite art and popular culture.

Far more thorough-going than such changes *within* the systems, of course, are the changes *of* the innovation producing systems themselves. The rise and potential fall of the public service broadcasting systems in some European countries is a good example of such structural change (cf. Rosengren et al., 1996; Hillve and Rosengren, 1996; Hillve et al., 1997).

With respect to mass media and mass communications, a basic distinction must be made between at least two pairs of different relationships between media and innovations:

- innovations actually produced within the mass media system, vs. innovations only disseminated by the media, *and*
- innovations discussed and criticized by the media, vs. innovations only reported upon by the media.

Innovations produced within esoteric reward systems (such as basic science) tend to be neglected or, at best, reported by the media only in connection with so-called 'Summary Events' visualizing slow societal processes otherwise difficult to perceive (graduation ceremonies, prize ceremonies, anniversaries, and the like; cf. Rosengren et al., 1975: 318ff.). Innovations produced within independent reward systems (such as applied science) are sometimes both reported and discussed by the media, and this may be even more so for innovations produced within semi-independent systems (such as élite art and literature). Innovations produced within sub-cultural reward systems (such as jazz, or radical science) lead a precarious existence in the media: they may be completely neglected or overwhelmed by media attention. Innovations produced within heterocultural systems, finally, are the bread and butter of mass media organizations and mass media audiences.

It may be a matter of discussion, perhaps – and certainly a matter of definition – whether the mass media produce any innovations at all, rather than just variations of old innovations. But to the extent that they do produce any innovations, their predominant type of reward system is the heterocultural one, characterized by the facts that other people than fellow innovators consume the innovations, allocate material rewards, allocate symbolic rewards, and set the norms for the innovations. It should be remembered, though, that traditional mass media have sometimes kept considerable portions of available space and time open to innovations produced within independent, semi-independent and sub-cultural reward systems. This is especially true for the public service mass media. It is less true, of course, for mass media operating on a commercial market (cf. Rosengren et al., 1996; Hillve and Rosengren, 1996; Hillve et al., 1997). Actually, this area may be where the typology's utility stands out most clearly.

In terms of the typology just presented, the widespread fears of imminent changes in the quality of European broadcasting programming supposedly to follow in the wake of the transition from a public service media system to a market oriented one could be expressed as originating in a change *from* a media system in which programming itself (and especially some types of programs) is being produced to a considerable extent within semi-independent or sub-cultural reward systems, *to* a system in which programming itself, as well as most types of its content, is produced almost exclusively within a hetero-cultural reward system.

The standards actually used in the different reward systems show considerable variation, of course, and this variation must of necessity affect both the 'horizontal' relations between mass media and other societal institutions, and the 'vertical' relations in which mass media engage in their capacity as agents of socialization (Rosengren, 1994: 7). What interests us in this connection is the long-term consequences for large societal institutions such as art and literature of the assumed societal sea change shortly discussed above: the fact that the economic system of society seems to be taking the lead over the other large societal systems: religion and politics, art and literature, science, technology and scholarship.

4. Some empirical studies of the literary system

The extent to which the economic system has indeed taken the lead is difficult to measure with some precision, of course. It would take a number of large-scale longitudinal studies built on the combined use of economic, social and cultural indicators (cf. Melischek et al., 1984; Rosengren, 1989, 1992) and showing that phenomena tapped by economic indicators tend to influence phenomena tapped by social and cultural indicators significantly more than *vice versa*. Such overarching studies would have to be accompanied by detailed case studies of book publishing and book reviewing, along the lines opened up by various productive research groups such as those in Siegen (cf., for instance, Rusch, 1995) and Tilburg (cf., for instance, van Rees, 1983, 1987; van Rees and Vermunt, 1996; Verdaasdonk, 1983, 1987).

In this article a more limited approach will be applied. The 'mentions technique' introduced by Rosengren (1961, 1968: 25ff., 1983: 36ff.; cf. also Rosengren, 1981, 1984b, 1985a,b, 1987, 1990; Melischek, 1984) offers a set of cultural indicators by means of which some aspects of the macro trends just discussed may be observed. Basically, the technique is a variant of the well-known citation and co-citation analysis technique (Borgman, 1990), and as it happened, the former seems to have anticipated some developments of the latter (cf. White, 1990: 89).

By counting cases in which a literary author is mentioned in reviews of books written by other authors than the author in question, it is possible to produce valid and reliable measures of the attention given to an author – or to a given group of authors – by the literary establishment as represented by literary critics and reviewers in the daily press as well as in literary magazines etc. It is also possible to follow the rise and decline of entire cohorts of writers – say, writers of a 'romantic' or 'realistic generation', thus offering quantitative descriptions of the way literary periods phase into each other – descriptions which are much more precise than traditional verbal descriptions. It is also quite possible, for instance, to measure the increase or decrease of a group of authors generally characterized as 'popular authors', thus being part of society's economic system as much as – or more than – its literary system (cf. below).

The reputations of cohorts or other groups of literary writers tend to follow patterns known from other types of diffusion research (Rogers, 1995), growth taking the shape of the well known S-curve; decline, the shape of an inverted exponential curve

(see Rosengren, 1983: 64ff.). Fig. 3 presents the rise and fall of a number of literary cohorts in the Swedish literary system, featuring several examples of those two curves of growth and decline. (The division into cohorts was made in agreement with generally accepted periodizations of Swedish and general history of literature. For practical reasons, the older cohorts – among which many writers have by now been put to rest in the haven of more or less total oblivion – had to be made much wider than the more recent ones.)

The data are based on samples of literary mentions as defined above, in principle representative of all mentions in all literary book reviews in a number of leading Swedish newspapers and literary magizines, during three periods of measurements: 1876–92, 1957–61 and 1966–76. The periods of measurement were chosen for a mélange of practical and theoretical reasons.

The curves are based on the proportion of mentions having been given to each cohort of authors during the periods investigated. Raw data have then been fitted to the theoretical shapes of the S-curve and the inverted exponential curve. The same type of analysis was undertaken using two different sets of cohorts, based on six and ten cohorts, respectively – just as more or less voluminous histories of literature may differ in their periodization. In principle, the same type of results were found, the results based on ten cohorts being more fine-grained, of course, than the results based on six cohorts only. The results presented in this article stem from analyses based on the ten-cohort division. For further technical details, including the sampling procedures used, as well as some arguments for the generational periodization, the interested reader is referred to Rosengren (1968, 1983).

In our case we are interested especially in the seven cohorts born during the 19th and 20th century. It will be seen that each one of them covers writers born during approximately two decades. What interests us here is that the rising curve of the cohort of writers born 1916–40 seems to be prematurely broken, the result being that the rising curve of the cohort born after 1941 crosses the curves of the two generations born 1897–1915 and 1916–40, respectively, at about the same time: around the upcoming turn of the millennium.

The crossing date itself, of course, is based on an extrapolation of empirical data from the periods of measurement (cf. above). Such extrapolations, however, both towards the right and left of similar figures, have proved surprisingly robust when confronted with historical data about literary periods as traditionally presented in authoritative histories of literature (cf. Rosengren, 1983: 70ff.).

How, then, should we interpret the anomaly of the curves for the two literary generations born 1916–40, 1941+?

5. A sea change?

Remembering the argumentation in the beginning of this article, it is tempting to interpret the anomaly in terms of an increasing prevalence of the economic sector in society, now shaping not only what has traditionally been called popular culture and popular literature, but also what has traditionally been called the fine arts in general,

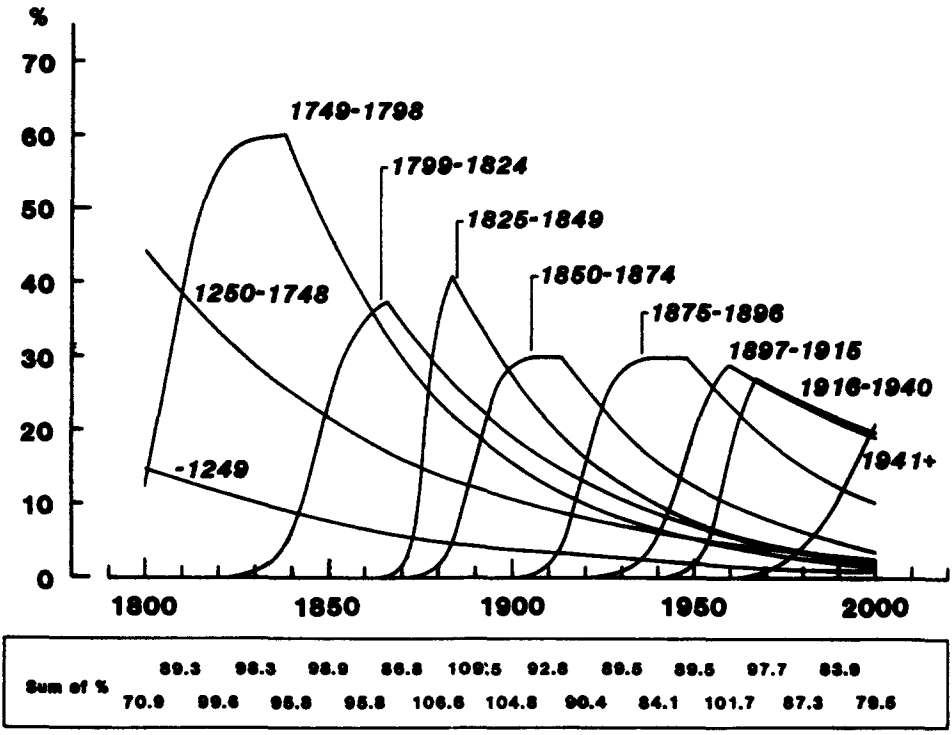

Fig. 2. The literary frame of reference:
Theoretical curves of growth and decay for ten cohorts of writers.

and *belles lettres* in particular. If the interpretation is correct, it implies not just another shift of generations, but a sea change affecting the whole literary system. Such a change affects not only the generation carrying the new banner, but also the positions of previous generations – all of a sudden finding themselves overshadowed by a group of arrogant young people, 'upstart crowes' very consciously neglecting the rules of the game as known and respected by previous generations.

In the case at hand, the literary generation born in the period 1916–40 – which in the 1960's and 1970's was about to be the leading generation of the Swedish literary field – should be the one primarily to be hit by the sea change. In Fig. 2 we see that they were indeed hit hard. Their curve of expansion was prematurely broken, and they are now heading towards oblivion at much the same rate as the generation before them, born during the period 1897–1915. There is no precedence for such a development. The closest we come to a parallel in the Swedish literary system is when the realist/naturalist generation of August Strindberg – influenced by Balzac, Dickens and Zola – had their breakthrough around 1880, heralded by Strindberg's novel, *The Red Chamber* (which appeared in late 1879). But according to Fig. 2, even that breakthrough did not erase a whole generation the way the imminent breakthrough of the 1941+ generation threatens to do.

Then, of course, the realistic/naturalistic breakthrough did not imply a change of the whole literary system as such. It was no sea change of the type which we may well be facing right now: the change from a two-tiered system of élite and popular literature embedded in a culture, to a system in which what remains of élite literature will have to try and live on, willy-nilly accepting the conditions prescribed by popular culture, including PR and sales promotion campaigns primarily based on high visibility in popular media – divorces, warts and all. In terms of the reward system as modelled above: a change from a semi-independent and/or sub-cultural system to a sub-cultural and/or hetero-cultural system. Obviously, there are still literary critics around, and they set, apply and impose their norms, much as before. But the norms of the market seem to be as strong as those of the critics, sometimes stronger.

These are speculations, of course, to be tested in future studies along the lines presented in Rosengren (1968, 1983, 1984b, 1985b, 1987, 1990). Some examples of what such future studies may look like may already be offered, however.

6. Signs in the wind

Studying various aspects of literary reviewing in the Swedish daily press, Rosengren (1983: 122ff.) demonstrated a rising trend for the proportion of mentions in literary reviews dedicated to authors located within two dominant genres of popular literature: crime/detective novels, and science fiction novels: from some 5–6% of the mentions in the mid 1950's to some 10–15% in the mid 1970's – which is as far as available data take us. Impressionistic studies of the same phenomenon during the last two decades suggest that this trend has not discontinued. The question whether it has actually been further strengthened can only be answered by continued measurements, preferably to be based on the mentions technique.

Crime/detective novels and science fiction novels, of course, are located within the popular outskirts of the literary system, featuring some authors acknowledged as first class writers by leading arbiters of the system, and many more being as a rule classified as popular writers, only occasionally heeded by those same arbiters. Unlike authors regarded as more 'serious' by the experts of the system, their reputation, even when they are grudgingly accepted by the arbiters, only seldom survive long after their death. But as they grow in number, and as they are increasingly accepted as more or less belonging to the system, the reputations of a growing proportion of them will no doubt survive their owners, sometimes probably for quite some time. Then the literary system of society may have yielded part of its independence to the economic system of society. Similar signs in the wind may be found in other types of data as well.

Other signs in the wind may be found in the fact that even in otherwise rather esoteric literary reviews isolated mentions of authors straddling the fence between élite and popular culture may sometimes be found – German protest singer Wolf Biermann, for instance, or Bob Dylan, and two Swedish poets/pop singers, Jacques Werup and Ulf Lundell (Rosengren, 1983: 87). Even artists such as the Beatles, who

– at least in the late 1960's and early 1970's – definitely belonged more to popular than to élite culture, did sometimes turn up in the literary reviews.

The quantitative indications of an imminent radical change of the literary system may be complemented by qualitative ones, focussing not on frequencies as such but on structures to be found in the literary frame of reference as measured by means of the mentions technique. Some authors tend to be mentioned together with some other authors more often than chance alone would have it, and such co-mentions form overarching networks of literary associations – often quite complex networks (exemplified in Rosengren, 1968 and 1983). The main structures are sometimes surrounded by isolated pairs or triads of authors tending to be mutually co-mentioned without being quite integrated into the overarching literary structure. During the period 1966–76, for instance, some such isolated pairs or triads in the reviewers frame of reference were

Raymond Chandler & Dashiell Hammett,
Grahame Greene & John LeCarré,
Aldous Huxley, George Orwell and Karin Boye (Rosengren, 1983: 166f.),

the three combinations featuring the penetration of three popular genres (two of which have just been mentioned) into the élite literary frame of reference: the detective novel, the spy novel, and the science fiction novel. Such isolated pairs or triads are sometimes remnants of old fields of literary associations, sometimes indicators of more complex literary structures to be.

Some signs of a coming lansdslide shift around AD 2,000, then, may be gleaned. Fig. 3 above shows, of course, that we have been seeing generational shifts in the literary frame of reference all the time. But the coming one may be more profound than the previous ones. In terms of Fig. 3, the previous significant shift took place around 1950, while – as we have just seen – the one which might have happened in the late 1960's was more or less abortive. But there seems to be a new one in the cards, and there are good reasons to suspect that the coming generational shift may be more profound than the previous ones – to be compared, perhaps, only with the one in the early 19th century, when the romanticists took over the scene, or the one in the early 1880's, when the realist/naturalist generation, in Sweden heralded by Strindberg, had their breakthrough.

7. Coda

Whether the literary system is becoming ever more dominated by society's economic system is still an open question, of course, to be empirically studied in future research and scholarship. It is notoriously easy to exaggerate changes of this kind. On the other hand, however, even very striking developments are sometimes not really perceived and understood until they actually are on the verge of culmination. The politization of the Swedish literary frame of reference – just as, probably, the literary frame of reference in many other countries as well – starting already in the

early 1960's and culminating in the late 1960's and early 1970's was clearly discerned and recognized in the public debate only shortly before its actual culmination. And it did not last all that long after its culmination (Rosengren, 1983: 138ff., cf. Rosengren, 1994: 15). In that sense, the water-shed year of 1968 may actually have marked more the end than the beginning of a new era, a long period of democratization – as at the time so many were hoping for. Perhaps the take-over of literature by the economic system will not last much longer, it might be argued. But it could be rejoined that the politization was a change *in* the literary system, while the assumed take-over of the literary system by the economic system may well imply a change, not *in*, but *of* the literary system.

What consequences will the presumed take-over have, one might well ask. Intuitively, it is rather natural to assume that in the long run, such thorough-going change will have thorough-going consequences. The rewards of the system will become ever-more crassly economic in nature, it may be assumed, and less and less they will be founded on praise and prizes distributed by highly esteemed colleagues. No doubt such basic shifts in the literary system will have to affect the form and content of literature itself.

Will this mean the death knell of literature as we know it? Will the result be 'desarts of vast Eternity', or, perhaps, a vitalization of the kind which in the days of Shakespeare's were brought to English literature? Which role in this huge macro process is being played – and will be played – by that 50-year-old mass medium, television? Will public service television survive, having to keep contact with commercial television at the same time as trying to keep up its social and cultural diversity, by – for instance – offering a watering place to some writers of élite novels and short stories, plays and poems? Will we be seeing, perhaps, a whole new type of works of art emerge from a combination of present video experiments and more or less traditional musicals, often based on popularized versions of classic literary masterpieces: an electronic '*Allkunstwerk*' based on a combination of words, pictures and sounds?

Only future studies will be able to tell. Especially comparative studies in the area might yield a rich harvest. Interestingly, however, the ongoing commercialization of not only literature but the fine arts across the board has already been parallelled by the rise of a new tradition of social science research and humanistic studies: Popular Culture. On both sides of the Atlantic, representatives of this tradition are busy studying those products of commercial culture which are so successfully sold not only to the so-called masses, but indeed, to all of us (cf., for instance, Chaney, 1996; Inglis, 1993; and – especially, perhaps – Inglis, 1996). The future may well belong to popular culture and to students of popular culture – the students of élite literature forming, perhaps, a small minority as Quixotic as those few authors who will persist in producing that strange type of literature. The victory of the economic sector of society within literary studies may thus stand out as almost complete.

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